SPARKY'S SCIENCE FACTS

How Do Frogs and Butterflies Change as They Grow?

Biology · Ages 5+

> **Short answer:** Frogs and butterflies go through big changes as they grow up. This is called metamorphosis.

How it works

- A frog starts as an egg in water. A tadpole hatches, with a tail and gills to breathe underwater.
- The tadpole grows legs, its tail shrinks, and it grows lungs. It becomes a small froglet, then a frog that can live on land.
- A butterfly starts as an egg on a leaf. A caterpillar hatches and eats and eats.
- The caterpillar makes a hard case called a chrysalis. Inside, it changes completely, and a butterfly comes out.

Key words: Metamorphosis: a big change in body shape; Larva: the young stage, like a caterpillar

Common mix-ups

- A tadpole is not a fish: it is a baby frog.
- A caterpillar does not just grow wings: inside the chrysalis its whole body is rebuilt.

Did you know? The African bullfrog is one of the biggest frogs in Africa. The father guards his tadpoles and even digs channels to save them when their pond dries up.

Try it: Look under leaves in a garden for tiny eggs or caterpillars. Only look, don't touch: some caterpillars have stinging hairs.

Ask Sparky: How long is a frog a tadpole? Do moths change like butterflies?